negotiations that I have attempted to trace for, largely anchored by the legacy of Akbar, they would result in an empire of magnificence that would endure a further 200 years after his passing.

Akbar was defined by restlessness, extraordinary courage, curiosity, strength, and intelligence. His shaping of the empire of the Mughals took it to heights it had never scaled before and would never rise to again. It is this swirling, luminous tapestry of action, adventure, ideas, and battles that I have tried to recreate here, a world now almost completely effaced, for all empires must fall. Except, sometimes, at dawn, in the charcoal shadows of the Red Fort, or in the husky alaap of a Dhrupad raag, or in the whispered sweep of a patterned kameez as a woman walks by, for a little while longer, a certain Mughal fragrance lingers.

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*Akbar's courtier and author of the biography of the emperor, the *Akbarnama*.

†The word Hindustan had been in use in Persia since the third century bce to refer to the land lying beyond the river Sindh, or Indus (pronounced Hind). The Mughals, therefore, referred to the land they came to rule as Hindustan (Hind-Stan), as a geographic and ethnic term, not a religious one. In this book, I have used the word Hindustan since it is the one the Mughals used, rather than India, used by the ancient Greek (Indike) and Latin (India) writers.

*In Arabic.

*Akbar is regarded by scholars as an Indian ruler despite the Central Asian origins of the Mughal dynasty because he was born, ruled, and died in the Indian subcontinent.

†Historians are agreed that the Mauryan and Mughal empires were the two largest Indianempires in the subcontinent. However, it should be noted that it is difficult to calculate their areas since there were no cartographic boundaries during those periods.

*The terms Turkic, Turk, Turki all refer to the people who spoke various dialects of Turkish (Turki). The region they occupied ranged from the Oxus River, Central Asia, up to the western frontiers of China. See Richard Eaton, *India in the Persianate Age*.

†Land of Islam.

*Indian Muslims.

†A clan of Indian Muslims, considered brave warriors but with a reputation till then of being brusque and rough-mannered.

‡A courtier at Akbar's court, he disapproved of Akbar's religious policies and wrote a covert, critical account of his reign. He was the most prolific translator of Akbar's ateliers.

*Slave-boys.